

the person that you are and not for what you wear. Unfortunately, this is easier said than done. College is a melting pot of students from all backgrounds. For the first time, you may find yourself in contact with others who come from a different economic background than you do. Try to remember that some students have more resources than others and that it is an expensive undertaking to try and keep up with those who are in another financial league.

George was not qualified to enter the big leagues, but he wanted to join the team all the same. George was attending the University of Southern California, a university with tuition of around \$20,000 a year. His parents, although not wealthy, had managed to save \$40,000 for his education. This amount combined with his student loans should have carried him through his four years. A rational calculation of his necessary budget didn't take into consideration the peer pressure George would encounter.

George grew up in rural Kansas. He was the high school valedictorian and football quarterback. These factors helped him to get accepted to numerous schools. George decided on USC because he had never seen the ocean and the excitement of Los Angeles was in stark contrast to his predictable hometown.

Upon arriving, George immediately felt like he didn't fit in. The majority of the other students came from wealthy families, and George found he didn't have the financial spending means available to him that they took for granted. In order to subsidize his activities as one of the crowd, George turned to credit cards. He felt that people treated him differently when they saw his "Gold Card." At first, it was difficult for him to use his new credit cards since his parents had always preached that debt was bad. But by paying his bills in full, George was able to tell himself that his credit card usage was all right since he wasn't accumulating a balance.

